LITTLE MOMENTS FOR BIG LAUGHS

Reflection Journal

Playful Heart PARENTING

By
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Congratulations on diving into the joy and silliness of ***Little Moments for Big Laughs!***

This companion journal is designed to help guide you through some friendly, shame-free self-reflection as you make your way through the book and try out some of the ideas.

If embracing a playful mindset feels challenging, this journal is here to help you explore what might be holding you back and celebrate the moments where it starts to feel easier and more natural.

Think of this as your space to capture memories, notice what works best for your family, and continue growing your playful mindset.

Note:

Even if you don't print this out and write in it, just reading through and reflecting as you go is great!

The goal is to help you gain insight into your own relationship with play and silliness, and to stay curious about how things unfold with your child when you try out some of the ideas. There's no right or wrong way to go about that.

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SELF-EMPATHY CHECKLIST

Take a moment to reflect on why being playful might feel hard for you right now. Check off anything that resonates, and be *generous* with yourself; all struggles are valid!

External Stressors

□ Work responsibilities or deadlines
□ Financial stress or uncertainty
□ Lack of childcare or support
□ Overloaded schedule or too many commitments
□ Recent or ongoing grief or loss
□ Family dynamics or relationship strain

Physical Challenges

□ Chronic exhaustion or sleep deprivation
□ Feeling unwell or recovering from illness
□ Hormonal changes (e.g., postpartum, menopause)
□ Lack of exercise or physical movement
□ Poor nutrition or skipping meals

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SELF-EMPATHY CHECKLIST

Mental and Emotional Load

□ Overwhelmed by decision-making and mental to-do lists
□ Anxiety about being judged or doing something "wrong"
□ Feeling disconnected from my inner child or sense of humor
□ Guilt about not being "fun enough" or "doing enough"
□ Struggling to balance everyone's needs, including my own

Environmental Factors

□ Housework or clutter feels overwhelming
□ Limited time to relax or recharge
□ Noise, overstimulation, or lack of quiet moments
□ Lack of a supportive community or friendships

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SELF-EMPATHY CHECKLIST

Other Factors

□ My personality naturally leans more serious or reserved
□ I didn't grow up in a playful environment, so this feels unfamiliar
□ I'm navigating big changes or transitions (e.g., a new baby, a move)
□ Other (feel free to jot down what comes to mind):

SELF-EMPATHY CHECKLIST

Checklist Reflection:

Take a breath, look at this list and recognize *all* the things you're navigating.

Consider speaking to yourself as you would to a friend: *"Of course it's hard to be playful. Look at everything you are holding!"*

It's *valid* that this feels challenging — parenting, life, and all the demands that come with them can weigh us down in ways we don't always notice.

Maybe this checklist has highlighted areas where you need a little extra care or support. You don't have to figure it all out right now.

With just a little intention — which you've already shown simply by reading this — you might be surprised at how silliness and playfulness can reenergize you.

Laughter can lighten this load, and those small moments of joy can actually help with the very things that feel overwhelming.

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

1. As you read through the book, which ideas immediately felt **doable or exciting** to you?

Did any make you smile as you read them or make you imagine your child enjoying and laughing?

List a couple or a few that stand out in your mind.

You can also use this space to jot down the numbers of the ideas in the book to remember those you'd like to try later!

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

2. Were there any ideas that felt **unrealistic or uncomfortable** for you?

You can list specific ones or a whole genre, if applicable.

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

3. Do you notice any **common themes** in the ideas that stood out to you as ***doable*?**

What might this tell you about your natural sense of humor or play style?

Reflect on what might influence you to gravitate towards these types of ideas.

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

4. Do you notice any **common themes** in the ideas that stood out to you as ***not* doable?**

What might this tell you about your natural sense of humor, play style, or capacity in general?

Reflect on what might influence you to avoid trying these types of ideas, and remember to refrain from judging yourself — self-empathy checklist, remember? We all have unique preferences.

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

5. **How do you feel** about the idea of silliness in general?

Does it come easily to you? Does it feel awkward? Somewhere in between?

YOUR PLAYFULNESS BASELINE

6. What was your **relationship with silliness** as a child? Do you remember moments of being silly and laughing a lot?

Were your parents frequently playful with you?

How much was laughter a part of connection in your family growing up?

Are any specific memories coming to mind for you as you reflect on this?

HOW TO USE THE NEXT SECTION

The next pages include five daily reflection prompts, followed by a weekly recap. How you choose to use them is entirely up to you.

One approach is to set a goal of trying five playful ideas within a week, using the five daily reflection pages to reflect each evening and the recap to look back on the week as a whole.

Or, if you prefer a more relaxed pace, treat this as a guide to reflect on the first five ideas you try — whether that takes a week, a month, or more.

Or, don't even make a "goal" at all! Just go at your own pace.

Even if you don't write your answers down, simply reading the questions and reflecting in your mind can give you some powerful insights and deepen your connection with your kids.

What matters most is showing up, being intentional, and letting playfulness unfold in a way that works for you.

DAILY REFLECTION #1

1. What idea did you try today, and how did your child respond?

2. How did you feel while trying this? Was it easy, or did it push you out of your comfort zone?

3. If the moment didn't go as planned, how did you adapt? What surprised you about the experience?

4. Would you try this one again? Or another, altered version of it?

DAILY REFLECTION #2

1. What idea did you try today, and how did your child respond?

2. How did you feel while trying this? Was it easy, or did it push you out of your comfort zone?

3. If the moment didn't go as planned, how did you adapt? What surprised you about the experience?

4. Would you try this one again? Or another, altered version of it?

DAILY REFLECTION #3

1. What idea did you try today, and how did your child respond?

2. How did you feel while trying this? Was it easy, or did it push you out of your comfort zone?

3. If the moment didn't go as planned, how did you adapt? What surprised you about the experience?

4. Would you try this one again? Or another, altered version of it?

DAILY REFLECTION #4

1. What idea did you try today, and how did your child respond?

2. How did you feel while trying this? Was it easy, or did it push you out of your comfort zone?

3. If the moment didn't go as planned, how did you adapt? What surprised you about the experience?

4. Would you try this one again? Or another, altered version of it?

DAILY REFLECTION #5

1. What idea did you try today, and how did your child respond?

2. How did you feel while trying this? Was it easy, or did it push you out of your comfort zone?

3. If the moment didn't go as planned, how did you adapt? What surprised you about the experience?

4. Would you try this one again? Or another, altered version of it?

RECAP

1. What moments stood out most to you from those first five?

2. Why do you think they resonated?

3. What was your favorite moment of laughter or connection with your child?

4. Were there any moments where silliness felt awkward or uncomfortable?

5. Did you notice any common patterns for “hits” or “flops” when it comes to initiating silliness?

STRENGTHENING THE PLAY-MUSCLE

1. Reflect on a time this week when you felt fully present in a playful moment.

What helped you stay in the moment?

2. What obstacles or doubts about being silly did you face this week? Were you able to work through them? If so, what was helpful?

3. Did you discover anything new about your child's sense of humor or personality?

STRENGTHENING THE PLAY-MUSCLE

4. How has working to embrace silliness impacted your overall mindset when it comes to parenting?

Have you noticed any changes (even the slightest) in your relationship with your child or in the overall mood in your home?

5. If you felt resistance or self-consciousness, where do you think that might have been coming from?

FAVORITES TRACKER

Use this space to document the ideas that brought the most laughter to your home. Revisit these favorites whenever you need a giggle!

IDEA #	NOTES/MEMORIES

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